THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER FOUR

“READ AVENGERS #1”

June 14 – July 28, 2007
Burbank & San Diego, California

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. FRY'S ELECTRONICS - COMPUTER AISLE - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, JUNE 14, 2007 - 3:10 P.M. PDT

A cavernous electronics warehouse decorated like a 1950s sci-fi movie, with a flying saucer crashed into the entrance. DAVID TIPTON (26), in a red employee polo and thick-rimmed glasses, patiently explains RAM upgrades to a CUSTOMER (40s) in a golf visor.

CUSTOMER
Wait. I know you. You're... you were in that thing.

DAVID
(practiced, polite)
Which thing?

CUSTOMER
The cop show. You were the guy who fixed the computer.

DAVID
I was the guy who fixed the computer on four different cop shows, sir.

CUSTOMER
That's it! "Enhance!" You said "enhance!"

DAVID
(smiling through pain)
I did say "enhance."

His flip phone buzzes in his pocket. He glances at it: a London number. He turns his back to the customer.

DAVID (CONT'D)
Hello?

EDGAR WRIGHT (V.O.)
(a quick, very British voice)
David! Edgar Wright. Is this a terrible time?

David nearly drops the RAM.

DAVID
No. It's a great time. I'm at work. I mean, a job. A different kind of work.

EDGAR WRIGHT (V.O.)
Brilliant. Listen, I've watched your test about forty times. Joe's watched it about forty-five. Kevin keeps stealing the DVD. We want you to be Hank Pym.

David goes very still. Behind him, the customer is reading a box of speakers aloud.

EDGAR WRIGHT (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Genius biochemist. Insecure. Brilliant. In over his head. The original Ant-Man, the founding Avenger. Every scene you did, you made him funny and heartbreaking at the same time. That's Hank.

DAVID
(voice cracking)
Mr. Wright, I've played "computer guy" fourteen times.

EDGAR WRIGHT (V.O.)
Well, now you get to be the computer guy who saves the world. Congratulations. We're announcing at Comic-Con in July. Until then, you are legally forbidden from telling anyone. Including your mum.

DAVID
My mom thinks I work at Fry's.

EDGAR WRIGHT (V.O.)
Perfect cover. Keep it.

Click. David turns around. The customer is waiting.

CUSTOMER
So? Will this RAM make my computer faster?

DAVID
(dazed, beaming)
Sir, today, everything is faster.

CUT TO:

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H LINE - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, JULY 25, 2007 - 11:40 P.M. PDT (COMIC-CON PREVIEW NIGHT)

A line of sleeping bags and lawn chairs snakes around the back of the convention center along the marina. Stormtroopers. Several Wolverines. A Jedi asleep on a cooler. And under a pop-up canopy, the SUPERHERO HYPE CREW, four message board regulars meeting in person for the first time.

GARY "SHELLHEAD1963" MORRIS (41), a high school chemistry teacher in a faded 1980s Iron Man T-shirt. PRIYA "NONERFSPLZ" SHAH (22), a UCLA engineering student in a homemade Wasp hoodie. DARNELL "WARMACHINEROX" JOHNSON (29), an Air Force veteran with a cooler of Gatorade. TOMMY "GAMMA_GAMMA_HEY" REYES (19), skinny, buzzing on energy drinks.

GARY
Two hundred and six posts I wrote saying the Kid Mayor would ruin Iron Man. Two hundred and six.

DARNELL
And how many have you written since the trailer rumors?

GARY
(ashamed)
Three hundred and twelve. All positive.

PRIYA
Rumor tonight on the boards is Marvel has a "surprise" at the panel. Something not about Iron Man.

TOMMY
It's Hulk footage. Has to be. They're shooting in Harlem right now. My cousin saw Amond Baker in a motion-capture suit on 125th Street eating a hot dog.

DARNELL
Nah. If it was Hulk, Universal would do their own panel. This is something else.

PRIYA
(pulling her Wasp hood up, quietly hopeful)
Ant-Man. Edgar Wright's been developing it forever. Hot Fuzz just came out. The timing is right.

GARY
Ant-Man? Nobody cares about Ant-Man.

PRIYA
Ant-Man is a FOUNDING Avenger, Gary. So is the Wasp. She NAMED the team.

A long pause. Darnell slowly lowers his Gatorade.

DARNELL
...Iron Man. Hulk. Ant-Man. Wasp.

TOMMY
That's... that's the cover of Avengers #1.

GARY
No. They wouldn't. Nobody's ever done that. Four different studios own half these guys.

PRIYA
Marvel owns all four of those guys, Gary.

The four of them look at each other in the orange glow of the streetlight. Somewhere down the line, someone starts playing the 1960s Iron Man cartoon theme on a ukulele.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - MARVEL SUITE - 19TH FLOOR - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 10:15 A.M. PDT

A hotel suite turned war room. A rack of panel outfits. Bagels everywhere (Marc's influence). Through the windows, the marina sparkles, and below, the

Hall H line wraps around the building like a snake.

KEVIN FEIGE (34) runs through a printed run-of-show with LENORA HAYES (42). JON FAVREAU (40) eats a bagel. JEFF BRIDGES (57), still bald from shooting, stretches on the carpet like a yoga instructor. TERRENCE HOWARD (38) is playing guitar softly. STAN LEE (84), in his trademark tinted glasses, holds court on the couch.

LENORA
Two hours. Six thousand five hundred people in Hall H, a live G4 broadcast, every trade, every blog, every camera phone in North America. If anyone says "Avengers," I will personally end your career.

FAVREAU
What if Stan says it?

LENORA
Stan is the one exception, because no lawyer has ever successfully stopped Stan from saying anything.

STAN LEE
(delighted)
Fifty years, and they still haven't figured me out!

In a corner by the window, ELXA BULLOCK (26) sits very still in a sleek gold dress, clutching her flip phone. Her brother, MARC-ANTHONY (25), sits down beside her. TAYIA BOYD (25) hovers nearby, fixing Marc's collar.

MARC-ANTHONY
You still haven't told her.

ELXA
I keep dialing. I get to the last digit and hang up.

TAYIA
Elxa. In three hours, your mother is going to find out on live television.

ELXA
I know.

MARC-ANTHONY
From G4. From ATTACK OF THE SHOW. A network whose main audience is teenage boys who think "Natasha Bullock" is a Bond villain.

ELXA
(half laughing, half crying)
She IS a Bond villain.

DAVID TIPTON sits nervously on the edge of an armchair across the room, in a suit that clearly cost his first Marvel paycheck. He's practicing deep breathing. Elxa looks over at him.

ELXA (CONT'D)
(calling across the room)
David. You okay?

DAVID
I'm fine. I'm great. I just realized six thousand people are going to look at me and know my name. I'm used to them looking at me and saying "enhance."

MARC-ANTHONY
Hey, Hank. You know the best part? In the comics, Hank Pym's whole problem is that he never believes he's as good as the other Avengers.

DAVID
Yeah?

MARC-ANTHONY
So you're already method.

David laughs, and the tension in his shoulders drops. Feige claps his hands.

FEIGE
Okay, everybody. Hall H in two hours. Remember: we show the footage, we announce ANT-MAN, we take questions, and we do NOT confirm anything else. Whatever the fans figure out, they figure out.

STAN LEE
(winking)
Oh, they'll figure it out, Kevin. They always do.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 1:00 P.M. PDT

A hangar-sized room. Six thousand five hundred seats, all full. Giant screens. A stage with a long table and the MARVEL STUDIOS logo. The crowd is a roar.

G4 cameras on cranes. In the front rows, the Superhero Hype crew: Gary, Priya, Darnell and Tommy, looking like they haven't slept, because they haven't.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen, please welcome the president of production at Marvel Studios... KEVIN FEIGE!

Feige walks out in his cap. Polite applause. Then a growing cheer. The fans know who he is now: the man who said "nobody gets nerfed."

FAN (O.S.)
NOBODY GETS NERFED!

The whole hall erupts in a chant: "NO-BO-DY! NO-BO-DY!" Feige laughs and holds up his hands.

FEIGE
Okay! Okay! I'm going to have that on my tombstone. Thank you, San Diego. Today we're going to show you a few things that, as of this morning, nobody outside of Marvel has seen. Please welcome the director of IRON MAN, Jon Favreau!

Favreau jogs out, waving. Big cheers.

FAVREAU
Hi, everybody! I'd tell you how excited I am, but my legal department is in the back row and I'm scared of her.

The camera finds Lenora, deadpan, in the wings. Laughter.

FAVREAU (CONT'D)
So let's not waste time. Lights, please.

The hall goes dark. The screens light up.

INT. HALL H - THE FOOTAGE - CONTINUOUS

Close on fire. A cave. The sound of a hammer on metal. Marc-Anthony as TONY STARK, bearded, bloody, sparks flying across his face, building the MARK I. The arc reactor glows blue.

MARC-ANTHONY (ON SCREEN)
They gave me a box of scraps. They really should have checked what was in the box.

A massive gray IRON SUIT smashes through a cave wall, flamethrowers blazing. It's real: Stan Winston's armor, in flames, on location. The hall SCREAMS.

Cut to the Malibu workshop: Tony tests the MARK II boot jets and crashes into the ceiling. Laughter. Cut to Pepper (Tayia) staring in horror at a robot fire extinguisher. Bigger laughter.

Cut to the red and gold MARK III, flying low over the actual Pacific Ocean at sunset, banking around the Santa Monica Pier.

Cut to a black-tie gala on the steps of a shimmering steel concert hall. Tony brushes past a woman in a gold and black gown. She doesn't even turn her head.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS WOMAN)
Your tie is crooked, Mr. Stark. Your ego, as always, is perfectly straight.

Tony stops, looks after her, intrigued. The camera lingers for half a second on a tiny gold WASP brooch on her shoulder. In the front row, Priya GRABS Darnell's arm so hard he yelps.

PRIYA
(whispering, frantic)
Did you see that? DID YOU SEE THE BROOCH?

Cut to Obadiah Stane (Bridges), bald, cigar, terrifying, looming over Tony in a dark room.

BRIDGES (ON SCREEN)
Tony, Tony. You think you're the only one who can build a suit?

The IRON MONGER, a towering, practical, ten-foot monster of steel, tears through a highway. Real cars flipping. Real explosions. Then black. Then the title:

IRON MAN. MAY 2, 2008.

The lights come up. The hall is on its feet. A deafening, sustained standing ovation that goes on for over a minute. Favreau stands at the podium, stunned by the noise.

FAVREAU
(shouting over the roar)
I'm gonna let the guy in the suit say hello!

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen... Jeff Bridges! Terrence Howard! Tayia Boyd! And TONY STARK himself... MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK!

The cast walks out. The roar doubles. Bridges waves his cigar. Terrence salutes. Tayia blows kisses. Marc-Anthony walks out last, sees the six thousand faces, and stops dead at the edge of the stage, overwhelmed. Then he smiles, cups his hands, and yells:

MARC-ANTHONY
IT'S NOT ILLEGAL IF NOBODY WROTE IT DOWN!

The entire hall screams it back: "IT'S NOT ILLEGAL IF NOBODY WROTE IT DOWN!" Gary, in the front row, wipes his eyes with his Iron Man T-shirt.

GARY
(to no one, choked up)
I was so wrong. I was so wrong.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - STAGE - CONTINUOUS

The cast is seated. Feige takes the mic again.

FEIGE
Before we take questions, there's one more thing. Something that, for this company, is a pretty big deal. Please welcome a filmmaker from England who's been working on a very small movie for a very long time. Mr. Edgar Wright!

EDGAR WRIGHT (33) bounds out, skinny, glasses, the crowd going wild. HOT FUZZ just came out and the geeks worship him. JOE CORNISH (38) follows, waving shyly.

EDGAR WRIGHT
Hello, San Diego! Joe and I have been writing this film since 2003, which in Hollywood years is roughly the Jurassic period. It's the story of a brilliant scientist who discovers a particle that can make a man as small as an insect, and of the extraordinary woman who becomes his partner.

A logo slams onto the giant screens: ANT-MAN. JULY 31, 2009.

The crowd ERUPTS. Priya is screaming so loudly that Tommy has to cover his ears.

EDGAR WRIGHT (CONT'D)
And now, if you'd please welcome... our Dr. Henry Pym, Mr. David Tipton!

David walks out from the wings, blinking at the lights. A wave of polite applause. Then someone in the crowd yells:

TOMMY (O.S.)
ENHANCE!

Laughter. David laughs too, leans into the mic.

DAVID
I've been waiting nine years for someone to yell that at me at Comic-Con. Thank you!

Big cheers. The crowd loves him instantly.

EDGAR WRIGHT
And our Janet van Dyne... the Wasp... Miss Elxa Bullock!

Elxa walks out in her gold dress. Two seconds of confused silence. Then a gasp ripples through six thousand people as they realize. It's the woman from the gala. The brooch.

PRIYA
(standing on her chair, screaming)
THE WASP WAS IN IRON MAN! SHE WAS IN IRON MAN!

The realization moves through Hall H like a shockwave. People turn to each other. Mouths open. Someone starts chanting. It grows.

CROWD
A-VEN-GERS! A-VEN-GERS! A-VEN-GERS!

On stage, Feige pulls his cap down over his eyes, grinning helplessly. Lenora, in the wings, puts her face in her hands. Stan Lee, in the front row of the reserved section, is laughing so hard his glasses fog up.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - NATASHA BULLOCK'S OFFICE - BURBANK - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 1:42 P.M. PDT

NATASHA BULLOCK (46) is in a budget meeting with three nervous executives when her assistant, MARCUS (20s), knocks and enters, pale.

MARCUS
Mrs. Bullock. You need to see G4.

NATASHA
I've never seen G4 in my life.

MARCUS
Your daughter is on it.

Natasha grabs the remote and switches the big flat screen from CNBC to G4. ATTACK OF THE SHOW's Comic-Con coverage. On screen: Elxa, in gold, waving to six thousand people. Under her, a lower third: "ELXA BULLOCK - JANET VAN DYNE / THE WASP - 'ANT-MAN' (MARVEL STUDIOS, JULY 2009)."

Natasha stands completely still. The executives shrink into their chairs.

NATASHA
(very quietly)
Everyone out.

They scramble out. Marcus closes the door. Natasha stares at the screen. Her BlackBerry buzzes. Then buzzes again. Then again. She ignores all of it. Then the desk phone rings: the private line. Only two people have that number. She answers.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Daddy.

INTERCUT - VICTOR AND JOAN, DONOHUE ESTATE, BEL AIR:

VICTOR DONOHUE (71) sits in his study beside JOAN DONOHUE (69). They are watching G4 on a television that has probably never shown G4 before. Victor is grinning.

VICTOR
So. Did you know?

NATASHA
Of course I didn't know. I made a rule, Daddy. No family in Donohue productions. I made it to protect this company from a lawsuit and to protect my children from people saying they didn't earn it. And she went and...

VICTOR
And she went and did it outside our company, at a studio that isn't ours, through an audition that wasn't ours, and earned it in front of the whole world. Tasha. She went around your rule the only way a Donohue could. By winning.

Natasha opens her mouth. Closes it.

JOAN
(leaning toward the phone)
Natasha, sweetheart. Your daughter's been sitting at that breakfast table for two years watching every door close on her because of our name. Today she opened one herself. Be angry tomorrow.

A long silence. Natasha looks at the screen. Elxa is laughing at something David said, radiant in a way her mother hasn't seen since Elxa was a teenager.

NATASHA
(very softly)
...She looks happy.

VICTOR
She looks like you did in 1980, at that premiere. The night Robert proposed to you in the parking lot.

Natasha sits down. Puts a hand over her eyes. Her shoulders shake once: a laugh, or something else.

NATASHA
I have to go call my daughter.

VICTOR
Tell her her grandfather says she's a Donohue.

JOAN
(gently)
Tell her her grandmother says she's herself.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - STAGE - Q AND A - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 1:55 P.M. PDT

A line of fans at the audience microphone. First in line: Priya, in her Wasp hoodie, trembling.

PRIYA
Hi. Hi. My name is Priya. I'm an engineering student at UCLA and I've been reading the Avengers since I was nine.

FEIGE
Hi, Priya.

PRIYA
So. Janet van Dyne is in IRON MAN. Janet van Dyne and Hank Pym are founding members of the Avengers. Iron Man and the Hulk are founding members of the Avengers. In AVENGERS #1, Loki tricks the Hulk and Thor shows up, and Marvel just got the Thor rights back last year...

(deep breath)
...Are you making the Avengers?

The hall goes so quiet you can hear the air conditioning. Six thousand five hundred people lean forward. Feige leans into his microphone. A long, agonizing pause.

FEIGE
Priya. Do you have a copy of AVENGERS #1?

PRIYA
...Yes?

FEIGE
Read it again. Very carefully.

The hall EXPLODES. Screaming. Stomping. People hugging strangers. Priya stumbles back from the microphone, crying, into Darnell's arms. Feige sits back and very deliberately says nothing else. Lenora, in the wings, gives him a thumbs up. That was legal.

NEXT FAN (DUSTIN, 30s)
(at the mic, wearing a Hulk mask)
Question for Marc-Anthony. What can you tell us about ANT-MAN?

MARC-ANTHONY
(leaning in, completely serious)
Honestly? It's a nature documentary. Ninety minutes. No humans. Just ants. Real ants. Edgar spent two years in a Brazilian rainforest with a macro lens. I narrate it. It's very moving. There's a scene where an ant carries a leaf for eleven minutes.

EDGAR WRIGHT
(instantly playing along)
Twelve. The director's cut is twelve.

MARC-ANTHONY
The director's cut is twelve.

Laughter rolls across the hall. Dustin, the Hulk-mask fan, laughs so hard his mask falls off.

FEIGE
Before we go, someone couldn't be here today because he's very busy turning green in New York City. He sent a message.

The screens light up. Shaky handheld footage: AMOND BAKER (25), in a full black motion-capture suit covered in white dots, standing on a closed-off 125th Street in Harlem. Behind him, the Apollo Theater marquee. Crew members everywhere.

AMOND (ON SCREEN)
Hey, San Diego! It's Amond. I'm in Harlem, doing the Hulk the real way, on the actual street, at three in the morning, in a suit with four hundred ping-pong balls glued to it.

(gesturing at himself)
Hulk doesn't wear pants. Hulk wears dots.

Laughter in the hall.

AMOND (ON SCREEN) (CONT'D)
I just want to say to my best friend: break a leg. And to Elxa: congratulations, sis. And to Hank Pym: welcome to the family. We have snacks.

(beat, a grin)
And to whoever's standing at that microphone asking if we're making the Avengers...

Off camera, a voice: "AMOND! NO!" It's LOUIS LETERRIER, sprinting into frame and putting his hand over the lens.

LETERRIER (ON SCREEN)
NON! NON! He is not allowed!

The video cuts to black. Hall H loses its collective mind.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - THE INTERNET DOES THE MATH

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 2:30 P.M. TO 11:59 P.M. PDT

YOUTUBE.COM - "IRON MAN COMIC CON FOOTAGE (CAM) HALL H" - uploaded by hallh_bootleg_007 - 218,447 views in 6 hours

Description: shot on my canon powershot from row 34 sorry for the shaking. THE MARK 1 IS REAL. THE IRON MONGER FLIPS REAL CARS. watch the gala part at 1:42 and look at her shoulder!!!!

This video has been removed due to a copyright claim by Marvel Entertainment, Inc. (3 reuploads remain live)

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "THE WASP WAS IN THE IRON MAN FOOTAGE - THEY'RE BUILDING THE AVENGERS" (Page 1 of 214)

NoNerfsPlz (Jul 27, 2:41 PM)
I ASKED THE QUESTION. THAT WAS ME AT THE MIC. HE TOLD ME TO REREAD AVENGERS #1. I am shaking and posting from the Hall H bathroom.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 27, 2:44 PM)
Let's do the math. AVENGERS #1 (1963): Iron Man, Hulk, Thor, Ant-Man, Wasp. Iron Man = May 2008. Hulk = June 2008. Ant-Man and Wasp = July 2009. Marvel got Thor's rights back in 2006. That's FOUR out of FIVE already announced. Thor is next. It's obvious.

WarMachineRox (Jul 27, 2:50 PM)
And Cap joins in AVENGERS #4. Found frozen in the ice. Marvel owns Cap too. It was part of the Merrill Lynch collateral. THEY PUT CAPTAIN AMERICA UP AS COLLATERAL FOR A REASON.

ShellHead1963 (Jul 27, 2:55 PM)
Ok, I'm going to be the voice of reason for once. Feige didn't confirm ANYTHING. Every studio teases things. Don't get your hopes up.

ShellHead1963 (Jul 27, 2:57 PM)
...I reread Avengers #1 on my phone in the parking lot. Loki tricks the Hulk. The team forms to stop him. My hopes are up. My hopes are in orbit.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Jul 27, 3:12 PM)
Amond literally almost said it on camera before the director tackled him. This man cannot keep a secret. I love him.

Repulsor_Ray (Jul 27, 3:20 PM)
it's elxa bullock btw. marc-anthony's SISTER. so that's three people from one family/friend group in marvel movies. the cronyism people are going to explode.

NoNerfsPlz (Jul 27, 3:24 PM)
She auditioned in secret and her own MOTHER didn't know. It's all over Deadline. Her mom has a no-family rule at Donohue. This was the opposite of nepotism. She went around her own family to earn it.

AIN'T IT COOL NEWS - JULY 27, 2007

HALL H EXPLODES: IRON MAN FOOTAGE IS THE REAL DEAL, AND THE WASP JUST CRASHED THE PARTY

Folks, I've been doing this for over a decade and I have never felt a room shake like that. The Mark I is a real, practical suit. The Iron Monger flips real cars on a real highway. And then Edgar Wright walks out, announces ANT-MAN, and reveals that the mystery woman in the IRON MAN gala footage is Janet van Dyne. Do you understand what this means? Marvel isn't making movies. Marvel is making a UNIVERSE. They won't confirm it. They don't have to.

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "MARVEL IS SECRETLY MAKING THE AVENGERS (PROOF INSIDE)" - Created July 27, 2007 - 41,206 members

Wall post - Jordan K. (University of Michigan): I made a chart. Iron Man (2008). Hulk (2008). Ant-Man and Wasp (2009). Thor (2010 or 2011??). Cap (2011?). AVENGERS (2012???). I'm calling it now. Screenshot this.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

hallhpriya: i asked kevin feige if they're making the avengers and he told me to reread avengers #1 and i cried in front of 6500 people. best day of my life 2:52 PM Jul 27th from txt

amondbaker: i didnt say anything. louis tackled me. i have been placed in a timeout 3:30 PM Jul 27th from web

edgarwright: the ant documentary is 12 minutes longer in the director's cut. thank you hall h 5:10 PM Jul 27th from web

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - PRESS ROOM - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 4:00 P.M. PDT

Round tables. Reporters from VARIETY, THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER, ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY, the L.A. TIMES and MTV. Elxa and David sit at one table, still glowing. A VARIETY REPORTER (40s) leans forward.

VARIETY REPORTER
Elxa, I have to ask. Your mother runs the biggest studio in the world. Did she know?

ELXA
No.

VARIETY REPORTER
Really?

ELXA
(a small, honest smile)
She found out from G4 about two hours ago. She called me on the way to the press room. I've never heard my mother cry before. She said, "I didn't know you could hide something from me." I said, "I learned from the best."

The reporters laugh. Then a THR REPORTER (30s) turns to David.

THR REPORTER
David, you're the unknown in this cast. Where were you a year ago?

David hesitates. Then decides to tell the truth.

DAVID
A year ago, my manager had stolen three years of my residuals and disappeared. I was broke. I couldn't afford headshots. Six weeks ago I was selling RAM at Fry's Electronics in Burbank.

(beat)
I told my mom today. She thought I got promoted to assistant manager.

THR REPORTER
(stunned)
And now you're a founding Avenger.

David opens his mouth. Lenora, standing behind the table, clears her throat very loudly.

DAVID
(quickly)
Now I'm Hank Pym in ANT-MAN. In 2009. Which is a standalone film. That's all I'm allowed to say.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - FAMILY ROOM - VIEW PARK - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 7:00 P.M. PDT

The family is gathered after dinner. The TV plays an ENTERTAINMENT TONIGHT recap: "COMIC-CON CHAOS: THE BULLOCKS TAKE OVER MARVEL!" Footage of Elxa

waving, the Hall H crowd chanting.

DESMOND (49) stands by the fireplace. CELESTE (47) sits on the couch with her tea. JULIAN (30) is slouched in an armchair. SIMONE (27) is curled up on the window seat. ESTHER (24) sits at the piano, playing softly.

TV HOST (V.O.)
...the Bullock siblings, Marc-Anthony and Elxa, now both part of Marvel's ambitious slate, along with best friend Amond Baker and former co-star Tayia Boyd. Fans are calling it "the Bullock Universe"...

JULIAN
(bitter)
"The Bullock Universe." Great.

SIMONE
Ant-Man, though. Ant-Man is kind of a weird choice. A guy who talks to ants.

ESTHER
(not looking up, playing)
Ant-Man is a founding Avenger. So is the Wasp. She named the team.

Everyone turns to look at Esther. Silence. She stops playing.

CELESTE
How on earth do you know that, sweetheart?

ESTHER
(smooth, instant)
It was on the news. The man at Comic-Con said it.

Celeste accepts this. Desmond doesn't even look at Esther. His eyes are on Simone. Simone notices. She smiles at him, a little too sweetly.

SIMONE
What, Daddy?

DESMOND
Nothing.

Desmond walks out of the room. Simone and Esther exchange a quick glance. Esther goes back to playing the piano.

CUT TO:

EXT. SMILLEY ESTATE - BACK GARDEN - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 7:20 P.M. PDT

Crickets. Desmond on his phone by the pool. RUSS KESSLER (V.O.) on the other end.

RUSS (V.O.)
I followed Simone for twelve days like you asked, Mr. Smilley.

DESMOND
And?

RUSS (V.O.)
And every Tuesday and Thursday at seven P.M., your daughter goes to a church basement on Crenshaw. A recovery meeting. She's been going for fourteen months. She's never missed one.

Desmond stops pacing.

RUSS (V.O.) (CONT'D)
She sits in the back and drinks bad coffee. Last Thursday she got her one-year chip. Everybody clapped. She cried. Nobody from your family was there.

A long silence. Desmond looks back at the house. Through the window he can see Simone on the window seat laughing at something Esther said.

DESMOND
(his voice strange)
...That's all?

RUSS (V.O.)
That's all. She's not your leak, Mr. Smilley. She's just a kid trying to stay sober.

Click. Desmond stands alone in the dark garden. For a moment, just a moment, something human flickers across his face. Then he puts it away.

DESMOND
(to himself)
Then who?

CUT TO:

EXT. GASLAMP QUARTER - ROOFTOP BAR - SAN DIEGO - NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 27, 2007 - 11:30 P.M. PDT

String lights. The Petco Park lights in the distance. Marc-Anthony, Elxa, David and Tayia sit at a corner table, shoes off, exhausted and happy. A couple of fans at the next table politely pretend not to notice them.

DAVID
This round's on me.

MARC-ANTHONY
David, you don't have to...

DAVID
No. Please. I have a paycheck. For the first time in two years I have a real paycheck. Let me buy my friends a drink.

Marc-Anthony looks at him, and understands. He nods.

MARC-ANTHONY
Thank you, Hank.

David waves to the waiter, beaming. Elxa leans her head on her brother's shoulder.

ELXA
Mom said she's proud of me.

MARC-ANTHONY
I know. She texted me in all caps. I think she broke her BlackBerry.

TAYIA
Six thousand people chanting "Avengers." Kevin's going to have a heart attack before 2012.

MARC-ANTHONY
Who said anything about 2012?

TAYIA
(sipping her drink, smug)
A Facebook group with forty thousand members.

Marc-Anthony laughs. His phone buzzes. He glances at it, turns slightly away, and reads.

TEXT MESSAGE - "PASTOR WILLIAMS" (saved under a fake name) TO MARC

FRI 7/27/07 11:34 PM

i watched the whole panel on g4 in my closet with headphones. u yelled kid mayor at 6500 people. ur sister is a WASP. im so happy for her. and for u. and amond almost got tackled lol

Marc smiles and types back, shielding the screen.

TEXT MESSAGE - MARC TO "PASTOR WILLIAMS"

FRI 7/27/07 11:36 PM

u watched it in a closet?? esther ur a grown woman

TEXT MESSAGE - "PASTOR WILLIAMS" TO MARC

FRI 7/27/07 11:37 PM

a grown woman whose dad thinks ur sister is a bond villain. closet was safer. goodnight mr stark

Elxa, still leaning on him, has seen the screen. She raises an eyebrow.

ELXA
(whispering)
"Pastor Williams"?

MARC-ANTHONY
(whispering back, deadpan)
He's a very supportive pastor.

ELXA
Mm-hm. That's a long text for a pastor.

MARC-ANTHONY
Elxa.

ELXA
(smiling, closing her eyes)
I didn't see anything. I'm good at keeping secrets now. Apparently.

Marc-Anthony looks out over the city. Somewhere across it, six thousand people are rereading a comic book from 1963.

FADE OUT.

SATURDAY MORNING HEADLINES

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 28, 2007

VARIETY - SAT JULY 28, 2007

MARVEL ROCKS HALL H: 'IRON MAN' SIZZLES, WRIGHT'S 'ANT-MAN' CAST

Tipton, Bullock to play Pym and van Dyne; Wasp's surprise cameo in "Iron Man" footage sparks fan frenzy. Feige to fans: "Read Avengers #1."

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - ANALYSIS - SAT JULY 28, 2007

IS MARVEL ASSEMBLING THE AVENGERS? STUDIO WON'T SAY, BUT THE MATH DOES

Four of the five founding Avengers from the 1963 comic are now attached to announced Marvel Studios films. Rival executives call the plan "either visionary or insane."

LOS ANGELES TIMES - CALENDAR - SAT JULY 28, 2007

From Fry's to Founding Avenger: The Unlikely Rise of David Tipton

Six weeks ago he sold computer memory in Burbank. Friday, 6,500 fans in San Diego yelled "Enhance!" at him with love.

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - EW.COM - "COMIC-CON 2007: WINNERS AND LOSERS"

WINNER: Marvel Studios. *A real suit, a real Iron Monger, a real Wasp, and the loudest standing ovation of the convention.*

WINNER: Elxa Bullock. *Kept a secret from the most powerful CEO in Hollywood. Her own mother.*

LOSER: Anyone who said Marvel couldn't make its own movies.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Week of Aug. 13, 2007)

Bullock Siblings Take Over Comic-Con

First Marc-Anthony, now Elxa: the Donohue grandchildren suit up for Marvel. Meanwhile, observers note a conspicuous silence from View Park.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER FOUR